

SHOE THROWN AT



AP

DELHI | Sneaker Attack

This was one surface-to-air missile the home minister couldn't have anticipated when he began briefing the media on April 7. Jarnail Singh, a Sikh journalist who was not satisfied with P. Chidambaram's explanation on whether the CBI had been pressured by the Government to give a clean chit to Jagdish Tytler for his alleged role in the 1984 anti-Sikh riots, flung a shoe at the home minister. The missile missed, and though Singh was escorted to a police station, the charges against him were dropped at Chidambaram's insistence. "We are a Gandhian party," said a Congress leader somewhat smugly. But the party has little to be smug about. On April 2, the CBI had submitted a "clean chit" for Tytler to a Delhi court. Though the Congress gave Lok Sabha tickets to both Tytler and Sajjan Kumar, another accused in the anti-Sikh riots, the party clearly does not want the issue highlighted or taken notice of before the Lok Sabha elections. During a visit to Amritsar last November, Rahul Gandhi had said, "Whatever happened during 1984 was wrong. I think the people involved should be brought to justice." At the press conference, Chidambaram also said, "This is an emotional issue", and then asked his security to be "gentle" with the journalist. Singh's gesture was triggered by Chidambaram's response that "the CBI had only given a report to the court. It was for the court to decide whether to accept or reject the report." An irate Singh said "I protest" loudly and proceeded to fling his footwear. Though he had aimed to miss, his missive may just have found its mark. *by Priya Sahgal*



A TV GRAB OF THE SHOE ATTACK ON CHIDAMBARAM (TOP) AND JARNAIL SINGH

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heads of state have been at the receiving end of flying shoes in the past: former US president George Bush and Chinese premier Wen Jiabao.